

Open HOUSE

Rajasthan's open jails, with little security and opportunities to learn and earn, are a success worth replicating countrywide

| By Rohit Parihar |

Manish Dixit, a young civil engineer, drives a Scorpio, uses the latest cellphone and lives in a well-furnished house. Sounds like another successful professional? Yes, but with a difference: Dixit is a convicted murderer serving a lengthy jail sentence in an 'open jail'. Dixit's prison at Sanganer, near Jaipur airport, is one of the 'open jails' started by the Rajasthan Government back in 1963 as an experiment. Almost half a century later, the concept has proved to be a success. Rajasthan's 13 open jails are home to 504 inmates; another 10 such jails are planned next year so as to have one open jail in each of the state's 33 districts.

The Sanganer facility is quite remarkable, or unremarkable. There are no high walls or visible security. The 170-odd residents live with their families, cook their own food, have televisions, coolers, refrigerators and even their own vehicles if they can afford it. Dixit certainly can. "There is freedom and comfort to grow but also watchful eyes to not let me stray again," he says. The idea of open jails,

conceptualised by former governor Sampurnanand, was borrowed from the West where open jails are fairly common. Based on their conduct, convicts in regular jails are first categorised as low-risk before being transferred. Open prisons have relaxed security and are generally used to prepare inmates for their release. Usually meant for white-collar criminals, inmates convicted of serious crimes, including murder and rape, can also be transferred to open prisons towards the end of their sentences if assessed as low-risk.

In India, the concept has been expanded to allow convicts to spend the final stretch of their terms with their families, to earn and work in nearby towns and even build their own homes in the fenceless jail premises. The final term in such jails is a transition phase to ready convicts for release and allow them to rework their social equations. Some inmates get married to other inmates; a few even have children in jail. There are 27 open jails across India, but most states have just one or two each. Rajasthan has the most and a visit to Sanganer jail ex-

plains why the concept works so well. Convicts who can afford it have built their own houses and go outside to work and earn. The 'jail' is actually located in a business zone which offers opportunities for inmates to find jobs.

Open jails such as this have a campus feel. Some are designed as a part of universities to let qualified inmates work on farms or laboratories and also earn degrees to help them fit into society. Suraj Mal, 32, a resident of Pal village near Jodhpur, was convicted of killing his sister-in-law. Lodged in an open jail located on the campus of the Agriculture Research Station, Jodhpur, he lives here with his wife and child. Suraj did his masters in philosophy and political science while he was in a regular jail. Working on the farm at the research station earns him Rs 2,600 a month, and, being a welder and carpenter by profession, he does odd jobs in the evenings. "The open jail has prepared me to make my living as a skilled worker once I am released," he says. "There are so many inspiring stories of inmates in open jails that it justifies a research chair on them," says P.K. Tiwari, Rajas-

